Methods for Communication Research

B.A. lecture in Fall Semester 2026
Credits: 2 (90 mins per week)

Introduction

This course provides a systematic introduction to empirical research methods in communication science. It covers the major stages of the research process, from research questions, operationalization, and sampling to data collection, analysis, academic writing, and research ethics.

Students will engage with major qualitative and quantitative methods, including interviews, content analysis, surveys, experiments, and experience sampling. Beyond learning how these methods are applied, students will critically evaluate and compare their assumptions, strengths, limitations, and suitability for different research questions.

Through readings, discussions, review papers, and the development of an empirical research proposal, the course develops both practical research skills and critical methodological literacy for understanding, evaluating, and conducting communication research.

Objectives

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- formulate feasible research questions and hypotheses.
- operationalize concepts and develop appropriate measurement strategies.
- select and apply suitable qualitative or quantitative research methods.
- critically compare and evaluate methodological approaches and research designs.
- conduct basic data processing and analysis.
- identify key ethical issues in empirical research.
- communicate research designs and methodological decisions effectively.
- apply methodological knowledge to independent research projects, including but not limited to the preparation of a bachelor's thesis.

Evaluation

Assignment	Points	% of grade
Research Proposal	30	30%

Research Project Presentation	20	20%
Review Papers	30 (10 × 3)	30%
Attendance & Class Participation	20	20%
Total	100	100%

Grade Conversion

Numerical Point	Grade Point
90 ≤ X ≤ 100	4.0
60 ≤ X < 90	0.1(X) - 5
0 ≤ X < 60	0

Assignments

Research Proposal (30 Points)

Write an empirical research proposal concerning a specific issue related to communication science and media research. The main body of the proposal should be structured as:

- Introduction to the topic, general research question and its relevance
- Literature review and theoretical framework, specific research questions or hypotheses
- Research method section, including your population of interest, *research design and data collecting plan* with **TWO** different methods.
- Critical discussion about what opportunities and challenges the two methods pose for your research question.
- Ethical consideration.

- The proposal should be 10-15 pages long, not including references, appendix, figures or tables.
- Use 1.5 line-spacing, Times New Roman / 宋体 12 pt., and standard 1-inch margins. You are expected to follow the APA 7th citation and writing style.
- Submit your final paper as a Word attachment before the deadline (To be announced).

Research Project Presentation (20 Points)

In preparation for your final proposal, you will give a presentation (Week 15 - Week 16) about your project to the class to gather feedback. You will also provide feedback for other people's

projects. Your feedback will be considered in the grade of class participation. Submit your presentation slides as a PDF attachment at your presentation day.

More information about the presentation will be announced in class.

Review Papers (30 Points)

Write review papers on **THREE** sessions (Week 2 - Week 10).

- The goal of review papers is to show that you have read and engaged critically with the reading material.
- For each of these sessions, write a short review of the topic and literature for this session.
- The review paper may address the following aspects:
    - Proposals of how the method described could be applied to a specific communication problem.
    - Elements of the methodology you found confusing or challenging.
    - Critical commentary about the writing or study design.
    - Questions the reading raises for you about the execution of the method.
    - Any other thoughts about the reading materials.
- A review paper should be no longer than 2 pages, not including references. Use 1.5 line-spacing, Times New Roman / 宋体 12 pt., and standard 1-inch margins.
- You are expected to follow the APA 7th citation and writing style.
- Each paper will weigh 10 points equally in the final grade.
- Submit your review paper as a Word attachment until Monday morning (9:00 AM) before the session at the latest.
- You should submit at least one review paper before Week 6.

Class Participation (20 Points)

You are expected to attend sessions, complete the required readings, and participate actively in discussions and Q&A sessions. Contributions should reflect familiarity with the materials and constructive engagement with the presenters and peers. In the last two sessions (Presentation I & II), you are expected to give feedback to your peer's work. Expectations on your attendance and class participation can be found in the Grading Criteria.

Deadlines

Unless otherwise specified, all tasks are set at **9:00 AM** on the deadline day (understood as Beijing Time). It is your responsibility to make sure that your work gets to the instructor by the listed deadline. Excuses such as "oops, the Internet was down in my building," "I was in another city without my laptop around," and "I was on a flight without Internet," will not be accepted. **PLEASE** plan some time for any unexpected emergency before the deadline.

If you cannot make a deadline, contact the instructor immediately and we can figure out a schedule that will work. Unless I hear from you, late assignments are penalized on its grade.

Grade Appeal Policy

All assignments will be returned with detailed feedback based on the established grading criteria. Grade appeals will only be considered if you have a specific disagreement with the feedback provided and believe that this discrepancy directly affects your score. Appeals based on any other reasons will not be accepted.

Please note that appeals are limited to individual assignment grades. Final course grades are calculated based on the cumulative scores of all components and are not subject to appeal.

If you wish to submit an appeal, you must reply to the grade notification email within 36 hours of receiving your score. Your appeal must include a clear explanation of your concern and any supporting evidence, if necessary. Be advised that submitting an appeal will trigger a complete re-evaluation of your assignment. While your grade may increase, it also remains possible for the score to remain unchanged.

Email Specifications

You should communicate with the instructor and submit your assignments using email. The Subject line of the message should say “Method: [Content] [Name]” where [Content] is the specific assignment you are submitting (i.e., research topic, research question, review paper 1/2/3, presentation slides, final paper) and [Name] is your Chinese full name.

Send short materials (research topic, research question) in the body of the email, not as an attachment. Send the presentation slides, review papers and the final paper each as an attachment.

Reading Requirement

Each week, you are expected to complete the “required readings.” These papers form the core foundation of the class content. In addition, some papers are listed as “recommended readings.” Although reading them is not mandatory, they can help deepen your understanding of the topic and support more active participation in class discussions.

Technology Use In Classroom

Laptops and tablets should **ONLY** be used for class-related activities, such as taking notes. If you are not using your device for these purposes, please lower your screen to minimize distractions for others and stay fully engaged in class discussions.

All other digital devices (e.g., smartphones, Nintendo Switch, etc.) must be turned off unless a phone is required for a specific in-class activity, such as scanning a QR code for a survey or quiz.

Texting, phone calls, emailing, and taking pictures or videos during class are not permitted. Using digital devices for non-class-related activities may result in dismissal from the session. Additionally, recording audio or video during class is strictly prohibited.

Class Environment

Please conduct yourself with courtesy and openness to others' opinions during class. Any form of demeaning or derogatory behavior toward fellow students, guests, or the instructor will not be tolerated and will result in dismissal from the session.

Absence

Attendance and class participation are components of your grade. If you must miss a class, contact the instructor by email at least **TWO** hours before the session. More information can be found in Grading Criteria.

Academic Misconduct

Any work you do must be original and reflect your own ideas, thoughts, and research. Do not plagiarize, fabricate or falsify evidence, or disregard the university ethical principles in any way.

Use of AI

You may use AI to help your study, but it should be in a good way.

- You may use generative AI tools in this course for brainstorming ideas, outlining, finding sources, overcoming writer's block, and getting feedback on your own writing. However, using AI to generate all or most of an assignment is considered academic misconduct.
- Assignments are designed to build your critical thinking, reading, research, and writing skills. Submitting someone else's work, reusing your past work without approval, or relying heavily on AI undermines those goals.

- Tools like spell check, grammar check, Grammarly, or ChatGPT may be used to support (but not replace) your writing. For example, you may use ChatGPT to clarify ideas or get suggestions, not to write full drafts. When in doubt, ask before submitting.
- In your assignments, you **MUST** clearly declare the use of AI in the form of footnotes, including the AI-generated content, the AI model used, the purpose, and the prompts employed. **Any undisclosed use of AI will be considered academic misconduct.**

Some ways I recommend you to get benefits from AI in this course:

- Helping to revise the paper/presentation structure.
- Searching for examples, cases to enrich the presentation.
- Generating pictures, graphs for your slides.
- Checking your writing and grammar.
- Summarizing the course content and mind mapping.
- Mentoring the development of your research (not replace your own thinking and writing).

Copying or Recording of Lectures

Course materials prepared by the instructor, as well as content of all lectures presented by the instructor, are the instructor's property. Video and audio recordings of lectures without the instructor's consent is prohibited.

Unless the instructor gives explicit permission, all course materials, including slides, and grading criteria must not be transferred or transmitted to any other person, whether or not that individual is enrolled in the course.

Schedule

Week 1 Introduction

Required readings: The syllabus

Week 2 Research Basis and Problem Formulation

Required readings: Booth et al. (2008) (pp. 33-47), Hargittai (2007)
Task: Submit your research topic and question(s) by email before Friday.

Week 3 Literature Review and Operationalization

Required readings: Hargittai (2005), Babbie (2021) (pp. 123-144)
Recommended readings: Zhang & Jung (2023)

Task: Submit your revised research question(s) by email before Friday.

Week 4 Population and Sampling Strategies

Required readings: Babbie (2021) (pp. 183-211), Mellon & Prosser (2017)
Recommended readings: Humphreys (2020)
Task: Submit your finalized research question(s) by email before Friday if needed.

Week 5 Interview

Required readings: Boyd (2016), Marwick & boyd (2014)

Week 6 Qualitative Content Analysis

Required readings: Hsieh & Shannon (2005)
Recommended readings: Gallagher & Savage (2015)
Task: Submit at least one review paper before Week 6 session day.

Week 7 Survey

Required readings: van Selm & Jankowski (2006), Hargittai & Walejko (2008)
Recommended readings: Walejko (2009)

Week 8 Experiment

Required readings: Thorson et al. (2012), Sundar & Nass (2001)
Recommended readings: O'Keefe (2003)

Week 9 Quantitative Content Analysis

Required readings: Gao (2016)
Recommended readings: Lombard et al. (2002)

Week 10 Experience Sampling Method

Required readings: Kubey et al. (1996), Nguyen & Hargittai (2024)
Recommended readings: Hofer (2020).
Task: Assign your preferred presentation date in class.

Week 11 Data Processing and Basic Statistical Analysis I

Required readings: Babbie (2021) (pp. 415–438)

Recommended readings: Hargittai (2010)

Week 12 Data Processing and Basic Statistical Analysis II

Required readings: Babbie (2021) (pp. 439–456)
Recommended readings: Ellison et al. (2007)

Week 13 Academic Writing for Empirical Research

Required readings: Bem (1987) (pp. 171–201), Cotos et al. (2017)
Recommended readings: Mellon & Prosser (2017) (Reread it !)

Week 14 Frontiers in Research Ethics

Required readings: Zimmer (2010)
Recommended readings: Kramer et al. (2014)

Week 15 Presentations Session I

Task: Submit your presentation slides on the presentation day.

Week 16 Presentations Session II

Task: Submit your presentation slides on the presentation day.

Bibliography

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